30 Days of World Building, Summer 2019

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Introduction

This collection of writing exercises was written in response to the *30 Days of World Building* challenge created by *Stephanie Bryant* from June 4th until July 4th.

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[level-1] [level-1]0

Day 1

The exercise for this first day is this:

> Get out a map or go to an international website like National Geographic. Look every- where. Antarctica. Saudi Arabia. The rainforests of Brazil. The rainforests of Central California. Look at how the different climates behave and appear.
>
> The first fifteen minute exercise is to write down all the different climates you can think of– if you need to just say a city name, do it. Sometimes "Seattle" is more evocative than "northern damp temperate climate." Write these names down in a list.

> Then, go through that list and write one or two words that describe how that climate, either the word itself or the way the place itself may have made you feel, if you've been there before. Try to stick to abstract adjectives; emotional words, if you can, but nouns are also okay.

Simple enough - though I think they might mean "biome" where they say "climate." And I'm not sure all of what I've listed are biomes, "officially."

Climate	Description
alpine mountains	divisive
badlands	sanguine, ironic
bayou	calm, saturated
chaparral	endurance, commitment
coral reef	childishness, riddles
equatorial archipelago	allegorical, precise
fen	playful
floodlands	folkart, communion
freshwater lake	plain-spoken
grasslands	eternal
holler	sneakiness
lowlands	historic, homely
mangrove swamp	consuming, decaying
marsh	honor
meadows	betrayal, beauty
moors	treason
ocean	introspection, philosophy
old growth forest	treacherous, ebulent
piedmont	prosperity, equality
pine forest	snide, caustic
rainforest	aggrevating, inspiring
redwood forest	weird
river delta	rigid, eternal
sandy desert	barren, spiritual
savanna	funny, excited
sea	opulence, reservation
shield	hardworking
steppes	stagnation
taiga	enthralling, catatonic
thicket	surprise
tidewater	creativity
tundra	challenging, introspective

Day 2

Before I get to today's exercise, I want to express a concern, of sorts, I have about being able accurately complete this challenge. I read through future days, and it seems that the challenge comes from the assumption that you have a vague idea of a story, and not a clear idea of what sort of world to

have.

I am coming at this from rather the opposite perspective: I have a notion of the world, but am looking for more stories to tell in it. This may mean that, going forward, I'll have to adjust how I respond to certain exercises.

The exercise for this second day is this:

> What role do you anticipate weather playing in your story? Do you have a lot of travel that you want to complicate with bad storms? Are you going to snow in your mighty heroes? Will there be a mighty battle, determined by sudden flooding? You actually don't need to know right now. Your exerise for today is to jot down ten plot devices that relate to weather, and what you think they do to the story (for example: a snow-in can turn the mood very claustrophobic... or very intimate).

Okay, ten plot devices related to weather, and what they can do to a story.

Device	Effect
calm at sea	Slowly building desperation. It's hard to know how long a calm will last when it star
flash flood	Sudden emergency. You've got to make choices about what to rescue, where to go, ri
fog	Obfuscation, opportunity for invisible things. Unseen murders.
weeks of rain	Discomfort, duldrums, break from routine. Canceled parties, missed opportunity.
heat wave	Concern for the future. Will it kill the crops? You've got time to plan.
thunderstorm	Natural fears. They're just... scary.
dust storm	Confusion, isolation, lasting destruction.
spring shower	Opportunity for romance, as two seek shelter from the sudden downpour.
very sunny	Noticing things you might otherwise not. The glint of a bracelet as a thief removes it
snowstorm	Holiday special! Or other community-based things.

I feel I could dive into any of these to turn them into an *adventure* or story set within *Teraum*. One reminds me of an idea I had recently, for an *adventure* set on a transoceanic cargo ship upon which the *party* has bought passage. Instead of scenes being defined by area, they'd be defined by what the main challenge each month is, and one of those months would be the calm month, in which the ship is becalmed, and the *party* has to figure out how to remedy that situation, by getting the ship to move or stretching the supplies.

Just for example.

Day 3

The exercise for the third day is this:

> Read over your list from Day 1 and then turn to a blank piece of paper. Close your eyes and think about what kind of feeling you like to have when you write or read. Write down four words that fit into that feeling: two adjectives, a verb, and a noun. Now return to the page with your list of climates and emotions. Do any of them match up? If they do, you have your climate. If not, try to find closest-match words.
>
> If you spend 10 solid minutes thinking about this and still can't decide, pick two climates that express moods you like. You can make up your mind later, and you can even build your world with both climates containing equally probable sites for your story.

What kind of story do I want to tell? One where people are desperate and innovative; one where reactive decision-making ruins plans; one where even the heroes are covered in mud, but probably not blood:

- desperate
- innovative
- react
- mud

So looking at the table from the first day's exercise, a few biomes stick out to me:

- I say "tidewater," is a setting for creativity - that's reasonably close to innovative. I also say "rainforests" are inspiring.
- "Thickets" are associated with surprise for me, that's close to react.
- "Freshwater lake" has plain-spoken, and floodlands has folkart, both of which are about the closest I can find in my list to mud.

So, where should the story be set, following this logic? Sounds like someplace that's normally subject to the tides, with lots of little bits of forest to hideaway in.

There's one part of my world that is very much like that: *Arathel County*, a coastal region north of humanity's largest city. A mix of wetlands, the whole region shifts with the tide, and again with spring flooding.

Day 4

The excercise for this fourth day is:

> For 15 minutes, jot down some of the Really Big Land Features you want in your story and just think "what if that were made by...." Write down a couple of causes for those features and scars, and stick it all into your notebook. Which scars are slow-force scars (like plate tectonics), and which are fast-forces (anything that takes less than 10,000 years is medium-to-fast in geological scales).

In yesterday's prompt, I was led to decide that *Arathel County* would be where I'm setting the stories and world-building these exercises are bringing me too.

That might make this challenge a bit tricky, since it's catered around *world*-building, not *small region*-building. In talking about this hallenge with a couple friends doing it, they also expressed some difficulty - the challenge seems to be drifting between "develop a world" and "develop the area of the world your story will be set in."

Anyway. The biggest land feature in the region is the region itself. It's on the eastern (and only known) coast of the *Old World*, north of the *Green River*, in a part of the world known as the *Green Delta*.

The *Old World*, as written so far, has four major *tectonic plates*. The *Green Delta* and the *Central Plains* to its east exist on one, which is subducting the *Optic Ocean*, the ocean to the region's west.

To the southeast, the *Central Plains* are obducting over the *Unseen Sea*, a massive desert which now exists a couple thousand feet under sea level; the tectonic border has formed a massive cliff known as the *Falling Coast*.

To the east, the *Central Plains* and *Unseen Sea* meet with the *Worldkeepers*, converging to form that mountain range.

So, four plates: under the *Green Delta* and *Central Plains*, under the *Optic Ocean*, under the *Unseen Sea*, and under the *Worldkeepers*.

That brings us back to *Arathel County*, which, despite being part of the *Green Delta*, is not on the same plate. The region was formerly a coral reef and archipelago of sandy shoals, in the *Optic Ocean*.

As the plates shifted, the region got obducted - I'm not sure if that's the proper word anymore, but "moved to be ontop of," - by the shifting of the *Green Delta* plate.

An aside: it's interesting not having names for these plates because the people in my setting wouldn't be aware of them. Also, I should point out,

while I'm using "plate tectonics" as the term, and the world does exist as a crust of plates, the plates' cause for movement is not like Earth's. Underneath the world is, basically, a zoo, called the *Worldkeep*, for all sorts of magic creatures. It's quite old by now and parts are collapsing in, and this is causing the world above to form plates and for them to move.

Anyway, *Arathel County* was a coral reef, but shifting of the plates caused it to end up above the shoreline. The coral got filled in with sediment over many years, and the sandy islands got worn down to dirt.

This has led to a region that's mostly gravel and sandy, with complex and often inter-connected cave regions. There's lots of ferns that grow in the region, and moss, and those sorts of things.

There's a river that runs through the river, the *Kaiper River*, though "runs" is an over-ambitious description. Fed exclusively by rainfall and springs in *Arathel County*, the river is low-volume and full of silt, slowly oozing toward the coast.

That's about it for notable geographic features in the region. The town of *Arathel* is built on the coast of the *Kaiper River*, and over time the area directly adjacent to the road leading to the town from the rest of the *Green Delta* has been cultivated into small scrappy farms. [level-1]

Supplements

Index

30 Days of World Building A series of prompts for building a fictional world. See See http://www.web-writer.net/fantasy/days/ or #30DaysOfWorldBuilding.

Bryant, Stephanie Creator of the *30 Days of World Building* challenge, and an Agile and SCRUM coach. See http://www.mortaine.com/

plate tectonics A theory describing the movement of rock segments under a plates surface leading to the formation of geographic features. See https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Plate_tectonics.

Teraum A tragically funny fantasy setting. See See https://emsenn.net/teraum/ or #Teraum.

Teraum, Arathel A sleepy, worn-down town.

Teraum, Arathel County A swampy and sandy county.

Teraum, Central Plains A large agricultural region, full of towns and castles.

Teraum, Falling Coast A massive cliff dividing a vast desert from the rest of the world.

Teraum, Green Delta A hospitable and well-settled region of the world.

Teraum, Green River A slow wide river, cutting through the world.

Teraum, Kaiper River A silty excuse for a river.

Teraum, Old World The large continent where most of history happened.

Teraum, Optic Ocean A large desert separating one part of the world from the other.

Teraum, Unseen Sea A desert so large it was first mistaken for a seabed.

Teraum, Worldkeepers A range of large mountains.

Teraum, Worldkeep A vast complex housing an unbelievable variety of magic lifeforms.

README

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